

Marathi, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/marathi/lessons/

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Preface

This is the Marathi volume of a wider project, written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Devanagari letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read नमस्कार *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. (A reader who already reads Devanagari simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Marathi is written in Devanagari, the script of Hindi and Sanskrit — but it is its own **Indo-Aryan** language, the tongue of Maharashtra, and one shaped by long contact with the Dravidian south. So the book keeps two contrasts in view: Marathi’s Sanskrit inheritance (shared with Hindi), and the ways it goes its own way — an extra letter ऌ, *three* grammatical genders where Hindi kept two, and gender marked on the *verb*. Roots are traced to Sanskrit and, where they reach, to the wider Indo-European family that also gave English its words — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any other language is assumed.

Same three commitments as the other volumes: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of connections; the cultural reason, not just the rule. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

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Devanagari for Marathi — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words. This page gathers the system, and flags what is special about *Marathi's* Devanagari.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** क ka, न na, म ma.
2. **A vowel sign (*mātrā*) changes it:** का k̄a, कि k̄i, की k̄ī, कु ku, के ke, को ko, कौ kau.
3. **A *halant* removes it,** and the bare consonant joins the next as a conjunct: स् + का → स्का; न् + य → न्य. The *anusvāra* dot ण̣ nasalises a vowel (बरं *barṇ*).

What is special about Marathi's Devanagari

- **The extra letter ऌ (*la*)** — a **retroflex l**, made with the tongue curled back. Hindi does *not* have it; Marathi shares it with the Dravidian languages to the south (Tamil *ḷ*, Kannada, etc.), a mark of centuries of contact. It appears in common words like *kāl̥* (“time”) and *phāl̥* (“fruit”).
- **The vowel ॲ / ॳ** for the English “a” of *cat* — added for English loanwords (*bn̥k*, “bank”).
- **Three genders.** Marathi keeps Sanskrit's masculine, feminine, *and* neuter, where Hindi collapsed to two — and it marks gender on verbs and adjectives more thoroughly than Hindi.

Marathi in the family

Marathi is **Indo-Aryan** (like Hindi, Punjabi, Bengali — descended from Sanskrit), spoken in Maharashtra. Its Devanagari and much of its formal vocabulary are shared with Hindi and Sanskrit; its sound system, its extra letter ष, and parts of its grammar bear the imprint of long contact with Dravidian. The lessons trace both threads.

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Marathi greetings — and, taught through them, how to read the Devanagari script and what makes Marathi its own language, not a dialect of Hindi. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs. *Practice lessons: lessons/MR-C01-*.md.*

1.1 नमस्कार (*namaskār*) — “greetings”

The letters in this word

(If you already read Devanagari, skim this.) Devanagari runs **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” न na, म ma, का kā, र ra. The stroke under स् (a *halant*) removes its vowel, so the bare *s* leans onto the next as a conjunct: स् + का → स्का. Read न·म·स्·का·र → *namaskār*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्कार (*namaskār*) = नमः (*namaḥ*, “a bow”) + कार (*kāra*, “the making of”), from Sanskrit — literally “the making of a bow.” It is the *same* word Kannada and Telugu borrowed, and close kin to Hindi’s *namaskār*. But note: where Hindi leans on *namaste*, Marathi’s everyday, all-purpose greeting is **namaskār** — one of many small ways the two Devanagari languages differ.

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together, respectful and neutral — it serves as both hello and goodbye, morning to night, to almost anyone. Warmer

and more casual is a simple *kāy mhñtā?* (“what do you say?,” i.e. “how’s it going?”), for friends.

1.2 धन्यवाद (*dhanyavād*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

New: ध *dha* (a breathy *d*), य *ya*, वा *vā*, द *da*, and the conjunct न्य (*na + ya*). Read ध·न्य·वा·द → *dhanyavād*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

धन्यवाद (*dhanyavād*) = Sanskrit *dhanya* (“worthy”) + *vāda* (“a saying”) — “an utterance of ‘[you are] worthy.’” The same Sanskrit word behind Hindi *dhanyavād*, Kannada *dhanyavāda*, Telugu *dhanyavādamulu*. Warmer, more spoken Marathi often says आभारी आहे (*ābhārī āhe*, “[I am grateful]”), on the root *ābhār*, “gratitude.”

1.3 हो (*ho*) — “yes”

The letters in this word

ह (*ha*) + the *o*-mātrā ो → हो (*ho*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

हो (*ho*, “yes”) is the plain affirmative — distinct from Hindi’s *hāmī*. Marathi builds its own everyday words on shared Indo-Aryan roots. The polite, fuller “yes” is *ho, baṛī āhe* (“yes, it’s fine”).

1.4 नाही (*nāhī*) — “no”

The letters in this word

ना (*nā*) + ही (*hī*) → *nāhī*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नाही (*nāhī*, “no / is not”) sits on the ancient negative *na-* — the *same* Proto-Indo-European **ne* behind English **no**, **not**, **none**, Latin *non*, and Hindi *nahī*. It doubles as “there isn’t”: Marathi, like Hindi, denies with this one word.

1.5 बरं (*barṇ*) — “okay, fine”

The letters in this word

ब (*ba*) + रं (*ra* with the *anusvāra* dot ँ, a light nasal) → *barṇ*. That dot on top nasalises the vowel.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

बरं (*barṇ*, “okay, fine, good, all right”) is the verbal shrug of Marathi — a soft “sure, fine,” the oil of everyday talk (its neutral form is *barē*). It is a genuinely Marathi word, not a Sanskrit loan.

1.6 येतो / येते (*yeto* / *yete*) — “I’ll take my leave”

The letters in this word

ये (*ye*) + तो (*to*) → *yeto*; ये + ते (*te*) → *yete*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Marathi, like the Dravidian languages to its south, will not say a bare “I’m leaving.” The everyday goodbye is येतो (*yeto*) — literally “I **come** [again],” a promise of return, never a final departure. (Fuller: *yeto*, *namaskār*.)

Grammar Lens

Marathi verbs carry gender. *yeto* is what a *man* says; a *woman* says येते (*yete*). The verb itself changes with the speaker’s gender — something Hindi does only in the past tense, but Marathi does in the present too. (And Marathi keeps *three* genders — masculine, feminine, and neuter — where Hindi kept only two.) You’ll meet this again at

every verb.

1.7 Recap

Marathi		Meaning
नमस्कार	<i>namaskār</i>	hello / goodbye
धन्यवाद	<i>dhanyavād</i>	thank you
हो	<i>ho</i>	yes
नाही	<i>nāhī</i>	no
बरं	<i>barṇ</i>	okay / fine
येतो / येते	<i>yeto / yete</i>	“I’ll be going” (m./f.)

Marathi is written in Devanagari like Hindi, but it is its own Indo-Aryan language: it prefers *namaskār*, keeps **three** genders, marks **gender on the verb** (*yeto/yete*), and — as the reference page shows — has an extra letter, ऌ (ḷa), that Hindi lacks. Next chapter: introducing yourself — *mājhe nāv...* (“my name...”) — and Marathi’s *tū / tumhī* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you are glad to meet them:

माझं नाव मीरा आहे. (mājhṃ nāv Mīra āhe — “My name is Mira.”)
तुमचं नाव काय आहे? (tumchṃ nāv kāy āhe — “What is your name?”)

Practice lessons: *lessons/MR-C02-*.md*.

2.1 नाव (nāv) — “name,” a word older than Europe

The letters in this word

ना (nā) + व (va) → नाव nāv.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नाव (nāv) ← Sanskrit नामन् (nāman, “name”). Watch the small Marathi shift: the Sanskrit *-m-* softened to *-v-*, so *nām* became **nāv** (Hindi kept the *m*: *nām*). That *nāman* goes back to PIE **h₃nómn*, — the same root as English **name** and **noun**, Latin *nōmen*, Greek *onoma*. A cousin from before either language existed.

Grammar Lens

A Marathi habit: soft consonants. *m*→*v* here is one of many softening shifts that distinguish Marathi from Hindi. Spot the shift and a Sanskrit word reads straight into Marathi.

2.2 माझं (*mājhṃ*) — “my,” and gender again

The letters in this word

मा (*mā*) + झं (*jha* with the *anusvāra* ँ) → *mājhṃ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

माझं (*mājhṃ*, “my”) sits on the first-person root *ma-* — the same root behind English **me**, **my**, **mine**, Latin *meus*, Hindi *merā*.

Grammar Lens

“My” agrees in three genders. माझा (*mājhā*, m.) / माझी (*mājhī*, f.) / माझं (*mājhṃ*, n.). The noun *nāṃ* (“name”) is **neuter**, so “my name” is *mājhṃ nāṃ*. You met this gender idea already in the goodbye *yeto/yete*; it runs through the whole language.

2.3 आहे (*āhe*) — “is,” and it comes last

The letters in this word

आ (*ā*, the standalone long-*ā* vowel) + हे (*he*) → आहे *āhe*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आहे (*āhe*, “is”) descends from Sanskrit अस्ति (*ásti*), on the root √*as* (“to be”). That √*as* / PIE **h₁es-* is the ancestor of Latin *est*, German *ist*, and English **is** itself — the oldest verb in the family, worn to *āhe* in Marathi.

Grammar Lens

The verb goes last. Marathi is subject–object–verb: “my name Mira is.” *āhe* sits at the end, and it changes with the subject — *mī āhe* (I am), *tū āhes* (you are), *tumhī āhāt* (you are, resp.), which you will use in the next chapter.

2.4 माझं नाव ...आहे — “my name is...”

माझं (my) + नाव (name) + आहे (is) = “my name is...” *Mājhm̐ nāv* *Arun āhe*. The *mājhm̐* is neuter to agree with *nāv*; the verb comes last.

2.5 तू / तुम्ही (*tū* / *tumhī*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

तू (*tū*, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit त्वम् (*tvam*), PIE **tū* — the root of English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, French *tu*, Hindi *tū*. तुम्ही (*tumhī*, respectful) is grammatically **plural** — honouring one person as many, exactly like French *vous*; it takes the plural copula *āhāt*.

Grammar Lens

A choice of respect, every time. *tū* for a friend or child; *tumhī* for an elder, a stranger, anyone you show courtesy to. Marathi makes you pick with each address.

2.6 काय (*kāy*) — “what”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

काय (*kāy*, “what”) grows from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE **k^wo-* — the root behind English **wh-** words and Latin *qu-*. Marathi keeps the *k-* plainly across its questions: *kāy* (what), *koṇ* (who), *kuṭhe* (where), *kā* (why), *kaśm̐* (how). Hear that opening *k-* and a question is coming.

2.7 तुमचं नाव काय आहे? — “what’s your name?”

तुमचं (*tumchm̐*, “your,” neuter to match *nāv*) + नाव + काय (what) + आहे (is) = “your name what is?”, verb last. The “your” set mirrors the “my” set: *mājhm̐* (my) / *tumchm̐* (your, resp.) / *tujhm̐* (your, familiar) — all neuter here before *nāv*. To a friend: तुझं नाव काय आहे? (*tujhm̐ nāv kāy āhe?*).

2.8 भेटून आनंद झाला (*bheṭūn ānand jhālā*) — “a joy to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is भेटून आनंद झाला — literally “having met [you], joy happened.” आनंद (*ānand*, “joy, bliss”) is **Sanskrit** — *ā-* (“fully”) + *nand* (“to rejoice”) — the *ānanda* of *sat-cit-ānanda* and a common given name. And *bheṭūn* is built on भेटणे (*bheṭṇe*, “to meet”), the verb behind Chapter 4’s *punhā bheṭū*.

2.9 The whole exchange

Marathi	English
माझं नाव मीरा आहे.	My name is Mira.
तुमचं नाव काय आहे?	What’s your name?
माझं नाव अरुण आहे.	My name is Arun.
भेटून आनंद झाला.	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *nāv* ($\rightarrow$ *name*), *mājhm̐* ($\rightarrow$ *my*), *kāy* ($\rightarrow$ *what*), *tū* ($\rightarrow$ *thou*). And two Marathi distinctives came back: three genders (on *mājhm̐*) and the verb *āhe* going **last**. Next chapter: *tumhā kase āhāt?* (“how are you?”).

Chapter 3

How Are You?

The everyday exchange after hello:

तुम्ही कसे आहात? (*tumhī kase āhāt* — “How are you?”)
मी बरा आहे, धन्यवाद. (*mī barā āhe, dhanyavād* — “I’m well, thank you.”)

Practice lessons: *lessons/MR-C03-*.md*.

3.1 कसा / कशी / कसं (*kasā / kaśī / kaṣṇ*) — “how”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कसा (*kasā*, “how”) is another *k*- question, from PIE **k^wo-* — the root behind English **how** (a *wh*- word that lost its *w*) and Latin *quo-modo* (“in what way,” → Spanish *cómo*).

Grammar Lens

“How” agrees with whom you ask. कसा (*kasā*, to a man) / कशी (*kaśī*, to a woman) / कसं (*kaṣṇ*, neuter). So “how are you?” shifts shape with the person addressed.

3.2 तुम्ही कसे आहात? — “how are you?”

तुम्ही (*tumhī*, resp. “you”) + कसे (*kase*, “how,” plural-agreeing) + आहात (*āhāt*, “are,” resp.) = “you how are?”, verb last. Because *tumhī* is grammatically plural, “how” appears as *kase* and the copula as *āhāt*. To a male friend: तू कसा आहेस? (*tū kasā āhes?*); to a female friend: तू कशी आहेस? (*tū kaśī āhes?*).

3.3 मी (*mī*) — “I”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मी (*mī*, “I”) descends from Sanskrit अहम् (*aham*), worn down to *mī*. That *aham* is PIE **h₁eg(H)om* — the ancestor of Latin **ego** and English **I**. Note its family tie to last chapter’s *mājhm* (“my”): the same first-person *m*- thread, as English pairs *I* with *me/my*.

Grammar Lens

“I am” is *mī āhe*. And “I’m fine” reaches back to Chapter 1’s *barṃ* in its gendered form: *mī barā āhe* (a man) / *mī barī āhe* (a woman).

3.4 मी बरा आहे — “I’m well, thank you”

मी (I) + बरा (*barā*, “well”) + आहे (am) = “I am well.” Chapter 1’s *barṃ* was the bare **neuter** “okay”; describing a person it takes their gender: *barā* (m.) / *barī* (f.). Add thanks: *mī barā āhe*, *dhanyavād*.

Grammar Lens

The copula changes with the subject. *mī āhe* (I am), *tū āhes* (you are), *tumhī āhāt* (you are, resp.) — one verb, reshaped for each person. Marathi marks *who* on the verb itself.

3.5 काही हरकत नाही (*kāhī harkat nāhī*) — “no problem”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

काही (*kāhī*, “any”) + हरकत (*harkat*, “objection”) + नाही (*nāhī*, “not”) = “[there is] no objection at all” — Marathi’s easy “you’re welcome / no problem.” Two histories meet: *nāhī* rides PIE **ne* (English **no**, **not**), while *harkat* is a **Perso-Arabic** loan (Arabic *ḥarakah*) — one of the many Persian and Arabic words Marathi absorbed under the Decan sultanates. An Indo-European negative wrapped around an Arabic noun.

3.6 The whole exchange

Marathi	English
तुम्ही कसे आहात?	How are you?
मी बरा आहे, धन्यवाद.	I'm well, thank you.
काही हरकत नाही.	No problem / you're welcome.

Roots banked: *kasā* (the *k*- questions, gender-agreeing), *mī* (*aham* → Latin *ego*, English *I*), *barā/barī* (now gendered), *harkat* (Arabic, the Deccan trade-and-court layer). Next chapter: the farewells — *punhā bhetū*.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Chapter 1 gave you the quick येतो (*yeto*, “I’ll come again”). Its explicit companion:

पुन्हा भेटू! (*punhā bheṭū* — “We’ll meet again!”)

Practice lessons: lessons/MR-CO4-.md.*

4.1 पुन्हा (*punhā*) — “again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पुन्हा (*punhā*, “again, back”) is from Sanskrit पुनर् (*punar*, “again”), a cousin of Latin *re-* (“back/again”) and the *puna-* of *punarjanma* (“re-birth”). To say a thing *punhā* is to send it round once more.

4.2 भेटू (*bheṭū*) — “(we’ll) meet”

The letters in this word

भे (*bhe*) + टू (*tū*, the **retroflex** ट *ṭa* with the long-*u*) → *bheṭū*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

भेटू (*bheṭū*) is a form of भेटणे (*bheṭṇe*, “to meet”), a native Marathi verb (the stem *bheṭ-* also gives *bheṭ*, “a meeting”). As *bheṭū* it means “let’s / we’ll meet” — the hopeful mood a goodbye wants.

Grammar Lens

“We” lives in the verb. *bheṭū* carries its own “we/let’s” in the *-ū* ending — no separate word for “we” needed. Unlike the present (*yeto/yete*), this future-wish form does *not* split by gender.

4.3 पुन्हा भेटू — “see you again”

पुन्हा (again) + भेटू (we’ll meet) = “**we’ll meet again**” — the explicit twin of Chapter 1’s *yeto*. Stack them for warmth: येतो, पुन्हा भेटू (*yeto, punhā bheṭū*). Neither word says “goodbye”; the parting is all return (Hindi *phir milenge*, Bengali *āshi*, Tamil *pōy varugirēṇ*).

4.4 उद्या भेटू (*udyā bheṭū*) — “see you tomorrow”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

उद्या (*udyā*, “tomorrow”) + भेटू (we’ll meet) = “we’ll meet tomorrow.” Unlike Hindi *kal* (which means *both* tomorrow and yesterday), Marathi keeps them apart: *udyā* (tomorrow) vs. काल (*kāl*, yesterday). The verb carries the future; the first word sets the day.

4.5 काळजी घ्या (*kāḷjī ghyā*) — “take care”

The letters in this word

काळजी carries ळ (*ḷa*), the **retroflex “l”** Marathi keeps (Hindi dropped it): का+ळ+जी → *kāḷjī*. Then घ्या (*ghyā*, “take,” resp.).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

काळजी (*kāḷjī*, “care, concern”) + घ्या (*ghyā*, “take”) = “take care.” Where *punhā bheṭū* looks to the next meeting, this looks after the person in between — “mind yourself until then.” The respectful घ्या (*ghyā*) matches *tumhā*; to a friend, काळजी घे (*kāḷjī ghe*), matching *tū*.

4.6 The farewells

Marathi	English
येतो / येते.	I'll be going. (“come again”)
पुन्हा भेटू.	See you again.
उद्या भेटू.	See you tomorrow.
काळजी घ्या.	Take care.

Roots banked: *punhā* (*punar* “again”), *bhetṇe* (“to meet”; “we” in the ending), *udyā* (tomorrow, kept apart from *kāl* yesterday), *kāl̥jī* (the retroflex ळ). Every Marathi goodbye is a **return** or a caring wish — never a bare “farewell.” Next chapter: the first real verbs — *mī marāṭhī bolto*.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, verbs of *being* and *meeting*. Now verbs that *act* — and sentences that move:

मी मराठी बोलतो. (*mī marāṭhī bolto* — “I speak Marathi.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/MR-C05-.md.*

5.1 बोलणे (*bolṇe*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

बो (*bo*) + ल (*la*) + णे (*ṇe*, the **retroflex** ण *ṇa*) → *bolṇe*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

बोलणे (*bolṇe*, “to speak”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb on the stem *bol-* (the same *bol-* as Hindi *bolnā*, Punjabi *bolṇā*). Its ending -णे (*-ṇe*) is Marathi’s **infinitive**: *bol-ṇe* “to speak,” *bheṭ-ṇe* “to meet,” *ye-ṇe* “to come.” Strip *-ṇe* for the stem (*bol-*).

Grammar Lens

Stem + gendered present ending. *mī bolto* (a man speaks) / *mī bolte* (a woman speaks) — the present tense splits by the speaker’s gender, as *yeto/yete* did. And it needs **no** separate “am”: the one word does the work, at the end of the sentence.

5.2 मी मराठी बोलतो — “I speak Marathi”

मी (I) + मराठी (*marāṭhī*, the object) + बोलतो (speak) — “I Marathi speak,” verb last (a woman: *mī marāṭhī bolte*). The name मराठी is “[the language] of महाराष्ट्र (*Mahārāṣṭra*)” — the “great realm,” *mahā* (“great,” cousin of Latin *magnus*, English *magnitude*) + *rāṣṭra* (“nation”). People *Marāṭhā*, land *Mahārāṣṭra*, tongue *marāṭhī* — one root.

5.3 राहणे (*rāhṇe*) — “to live, to stay”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

राहणे (*rāhṇe*, “to live, remain”) is from Sanskrit *rah-* (“to remain,” the same root as Hindi *rahnā*): *mī puṇyāt rāhto* (“I live in Pune”).

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. पुण्यात (*puṇyāt*) = पुणे (*Puṇe*, the city) + *-āt* (“in”), glued to the noun’s *end*. Marathi uses **postpositions**, verb last.

5.4 काम करणे (*kām karṇe*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

करणे (*karṇe*, “to do, make”) is from Sanskrit $\sqrt{kr}$ (“to do”), PIE $*k^{aw}er-$ — the very root inside Chapter 1’s नमस्कार (*namaskār* = “the *making* of a bow”) and कर्म (*karma*, “a thing *done*”). And काम (*kām*, “work”) is itself worn down from that *karma*. Marathi builds compounds as **noun** + करणे: काम करणे (*kām karṇe*, “work-do” = “to work”), *madat karṇe* (“to help”). Present, gendered: *mī kām karto/karte* (“I work”).

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Marathi	English
मी मराठी बोलतो / बोलते.	I speak Marathi.
मी पुण्यात राहतो / राहते.	I live in Pune.
मी काम करतो / करते.	I work.

One engine: an infinitive in *-ṇe*; a present of stem + a **gendered** ending (*-to* m. / *-te* f.) that folds in the “am”; the verb last; “in” on the noun’s tail. Roots banked: *bolṇe* (native), *marāṭhī* ($\leftarrow$ *Mahārāṣṭra* “great realm”), *rāhṇe* (*rah-* “remain”), *karṇe* ($\sqrt{kr}$ — root of *namaskār*, *karma*; *kām* $\leftarrow$ *karmā*). From here, Marathi only opens further.